

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SIERRA LEONE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the coast and forests of Sierra Leone, and one fight over a single beach showed that fishing communities, landowners, and conservationists, standing together, can stop a foreign-funded megaproject and win it all the way to the highest court. At Black Johnson, a secluded beach on the peninsula south of Freetown — rainforest rising behind it, a lagoon breeding the fish that feed the coast, sea turtles nesting on the sand — the government announced a plan to hand over a hundred hectares and more for a large Chinese-funded fishing harbour, with, it was widely feared, a fishmeal factory attached. To the people who knew the place, this was a disaster in the making: a fishmeal plant would strip the sea of the small fish that artisanal fishers and the nation depend on, poison the breeding grounds, and destroy a pristine forest and shore. They did not accept it. Landowners, fishing communities, conservationists, and ordinary citizens raised a storm — a petition signed by more than twenty thousand, a wave of national and international attention, a campaign to save the beach. Under the pressure, the government halted the project. And in the end, the country's Supreme Court ruled in the campaign's favour, securing the beach. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a fight is won. Black Johnson is a small, secluded place on the peninsula south of the capital, its hills covered in rainforest that shelters chimpanzees and protected birds, its lagoon a nursery where fish breed, its sands a place where turtles come to lay their eggs. The deal announced in the middle of 2021 would have handed a hundred hectares and more of this to a foreign state enterprise for a large harbour funded by a grant of tens of millions, part of a global infrastructure programme; and though the government insisted the facility was only a harbour, it was widely and credibly feared to include a fishmeal plant — a factory that grinds vast quantities of small fish into feed, stripping the very stocks that the coast eats and the artisanal fishers live by. Against this, a campaign rose that joined the landowners, the fishing communities, conservationists, and the wider public; it gathered a petition of more than twenty thousand names, drew national and international attention, and, when the government would not simply relent, pursued the matter through the courts to the highest bench in the land, which ruled to save the beach.

The Sierra Leone story teaches two things about defending land and sea here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the public storm, and the courts — pressed together. The second is distinctly Sierra Leonean, and it was won at Black Johnson. **A broad coalition — the fishing communities whose livelihoods and whose food are at stake, the landowners, the conservationists, and the wider public — that raises a public storm and carries the fight to the courts can stop even a foreign-funded megaproject.** That power — the defence of the fisheries and the food they provide, the pristine-ecosystem cause, the public storm, the broad coalition, and the courts — is Sierra Leone's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Black Johnson fight work as a model, and what a later community can copy, was the way it fused a cause of national survival — the fish that feed a poor country — to a cause of global conservation and a demand for legality that even a powerful foreign-backed deal could not simply override. A government may wave away a local objection, and a foreign partner may count on its influence; but a threat to the nation's food, joined to the loss of a pristine and globally valued ecosystem, and pressed through courts beyond the partner's reach, is far harder to dismiss. The campaign made the fish and the food everyone's concern, the beach and the forest a cause the world would notice, and the courts the final arbiter. Make it about the nation's fish and food, raise a storm the world hears, and take it to a court no partner can capture: that is the template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The community was **divided** — some local people, many without work, supported the harbour for the development and jobs it promised, and the opposition drew heavily on landowners and conservationists, so the fight carried a real tension between development and the environment that a campaign must face honestly. It is worth being especially candid about this division, because it distinguishes this fight from a simpler one. To a poor and largely unemployed local population, the promise of a harbour — jobs, wages, development — was not nothing, and some in the area welcomed it; the opposition drew heavily on landowners, some from the capital and beyond, and on conservationists, which allowed the project's backers to paint the resistance as the preference of the comfortable over the needs of the poor. A campaign that ignored this, or that treated those tempted by the jobs with contempt, would have handed its opponents a weapon and split the very community it needed. The Black Johnson campaign had to make its case not only against the harm but for a truer account of the development — the fisheries livelihoods that would be lost, the food that would vanish — and a community facing a similar promise must be ready to do the same, with respect for those who are tempted. The government **defended the project** and was

reluctant to act against a powerful foreign partner on whom it depends. The win came only **after years** and a Supreme Court ruling. And Black Johnson was **one beach**: the wider plunder of Sierra Leone's fisheries by foreign industrial fleets goes on. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of the fisheries cause, the public storm, and the courts — and the community division, the competing good of development, the foreign-partner dependence, and the wider threat that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a megaproject and assume "the government has signed with a powerful foreign partner and nothing can be done," and never document the harm to the fisheries, never raise the public storm, never carry it to the courts. They generate private worry without a public claim. The gap between a community that saves its beach and its fishery and one that loses them is rarely passion — Black Johnson's defenders had it in abundance. It is method: knowing how to make the case for the fisheries and the food, raise the public storm, build the broad coalition, and reach the courts.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Sierra Leonean system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a harbour, a fishmeal plant, a mine, or another destructive project:

```
STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the deal, the harm, and the leverage)
      |
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION         (build the evidence for the fisheries and the forest)
      |
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION      (build the broad coalition and raise the storm)
      |
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES      (the environment, the process, and the courts)
      |
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY        (raise a national and international storm)
```

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the public storm and the legal case at once; the coalition builds; a petition or a court filing is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, a beach saved, a fishery defended. The Black Johnson campaign did exactly this — it documented the harm to the fisheries and the forest, built a broad coalition, raised a storm, and carried the fight to the Supreme Court.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Sierra Leone's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The fisheries and the food they provide.** The threat to **artisanal fishing, fish stocks, and the nation's food** is a powerful, unifying argument, as it was at Black Johnson. The power of this lever lies in the peculiar reach of the fisheries argument in a country like Sierra Leone. Fish is not a marginal concern here but a staple of the national diet and the livelihood of whole coastal communities, and a project that threatens the fish stocks threatens something every citizen has a stake in — the food on the table and the price of it. A fishmeal plant, which converts great tonnages of the small fish people eat into feed for export, strikes directly at that shared interest, and framing a project as a threat to the nation's food rather than merely to a local environment broadens the concern from a single community to the country. It was exactly this national dimension — the fish that feed the poor — that gave the Black Johnson campaign its unusual breadth and force.
- **The pristine ecosystem.** A **protected forest, a fish-breeding lagoon, nesting turtles** give the fight a conservation cause and a global hook.
- **The public storm.** A **petition and a wave of national and international attention** can force a government's hand, as the storm did at Black Johnson.
- **The broad coalition.** A coalition of **fishing communities, landowners, conservationists, and the public** is broad and hard to dismiss.
- **The courts.** Sierra Leone's **courts, up to the Supreme Court**, are a real and — at Black Johnson — decisive lever. The courts hold a distinctive importance in a fight of this kind precisely because they lie beyond the reach of the influences that shape the rest of the decision. A government dependent on a powerful foreign partner, and reluctant to cross it, may resist every political and public pressure; but a court, ruling on the lawfulness of the deal, the adequacy of the environmental review, and the legality of the land acquisition, answers to the law rather than to the partner or the aid it brings. The Supreme Court's ruling secured Black Johnson in a way that political pressure alone might not have, placing the beach beyond the reach of a single government's will; a campaign that builds a rigorous legal case and is prepared to carry it to the highest court holds a lever that the foreign partner's influence cannot capture.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver clean, easy, total wins. The Black Johnson win came amid a **divided community**, against a **government that defended the project** and depended on a foreign partner, only **after years and a Supreme Court ruling**, and against a **wider threat that continues**. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Sierra Leone offers — the fisheries cause, the ecosystem, the public storm, the coalition, and the courts — as the defenders of Black Johnson used them, while facing the tensions honestly.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the deal — or the leverage — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Sierra Leonean development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The central government and the ministries. The **central government and the ministries** — fisheries, lands, finance, environment — grant the deals and the land, and champion the big projects, often as development brought by a foreign partner, and can be moved by the public storm, the courts, and the vote, as the government halted Black Johnson under pressure.

The foreign partners and financiers. **Foreign governments, state enterprises, and financiers** — a foreign grant, a state-owned company — fund and drive the megaprojects, and their involvement is both the project's strength and a point of scrutiny. It is worth understanding this double edge, because it shapes the whole strategy. A foreign grant or a state enterprise brings the project money, political weight, and a government eager to please a partner it depends on — a formidable strength; but that same foreign involvement is also a vulnerability, for a deal with a distant power over a nation's land and fish invites a particular scrutiny, at home and abroad, and a foreign partner sensitive to its international image may not welcome the association with an ecological disaster. A campaign can turn the foreign backing from a strength into a liability by shining a bright, well-documented light on what the deal would do, so that the partner and the government alike feel the cost of the association — as the international attention on Black Johnson made the deal an embarrassment.

The local communities and landowners. The **communities, the fishing communities, and the landowners** hold the land and the livelihoods at stake, and their stand — though it may be divided — carries weight, as Black Johnson's landowners and fishers showed.

The environment, the process, and the courts. The **environmental law, the process, and the courts** are real constraints and levers, open to scrutiny and challenge, as the Black Johnson process was challenged to the Supreme Court.

The community and the coalition. The **communities, the conservation and civil-society organisations, and the wider public** are the force that documents, raises the storm, and reaches the courts — the force that saved a beach.

The Journey of a Deal

A typical deal moves from a government announcement and a foreign-funded agreement, through **land acquisition and an environmental process**, toward construction — with the **community, the courts, and the public** able to document, raise the storm, challenge, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Sierra Leonean doors are the **fisheries-and-food case**, the **pristine-ecosystem cause**, the **public storm**, the **broad coalition**, and the **courts**. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **whether the harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem can be shown, whether a public storm can be raised, and whether the process was lawful**, because those are often where a deal can be stopped.

Follow the Deal, the Harm, and the Fisheries

Behind a project stand a proponent — the government, a foreign partner — and the officials who granted the deal. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly in Sierra Leone — **whether the project harms the fisheries, the fish stocks, and the nation's food, whether it destroys a pristine or protected ecosystem, whether the process and the land acquisition were lawful, and whether a public storm and a broad coalition can be raised.** Two

questions unlock most Sierra Leonean fights of this kind: **Can the harm to the fisheries, the food, and the ecosystem be shown, and a storm raised?** and **Was the process lawful, and can it be carried to the courts?** The fisheries-and-food case and the public storm are, together, the heart of most such Sierra Leonean campaigns. The two reinforce one another in a way particular to these fights: the fisheries-and-food case supplies the substance — the reason the whole nation should care — while the public storm supplies the force that turns that concern into pressure a government must feel. A campaign that makes the fisheries case only quietly, in submissions and reports, may be ignored; one that raises a storm without the substance of the fisheries threat may be dismissed as noise. Joined together — the case that the nation's food is at stake and the storm that makes that case impossible to ignore — they move a government, as they moved the government to pause at Black Johnson.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts, up to the Supreme Court**; the **environmental law and process**; the **conservation and civil-society organisations**, at home and international; the **free press and social media**; and the **public**, at home and abroad, whose storm moved the government. In Sierra Leone, the **fisheries-and-food case, the pristine-ecosystem cause, the public storm, the broad coalition, and the courts** are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a deal shown to devastate the fisheries and the food, to destroy a pristine ecosystem, to rest on a flawed process, and to face a public storm and the courts rarely proceeds — as the Black Johnson deal did not.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Sierra Leonean and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **harm to the fisheries, the food, and the ecosystem** can be shown, whether a **public storm** can be raised, whether the **process was flawed**, whether a **broad coalition** can be built, and whether the fight can be **carried to the courts**. Where the harm is clear and the storm is raised, Sierra Leone's levers are real, as Black Johnson showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the community was divided, the government defended the project, the win took years, and the wider threat continues.

Individual Step Success Rates

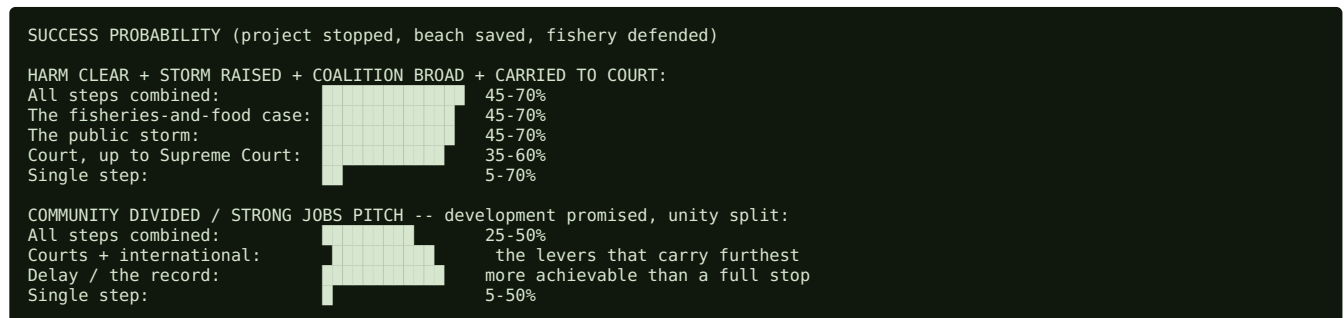
Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
The fisheries-and-food case	45-70%	months-years	low	The public and the nation roused
The pristine-ecosystem cause	40-65%	ongoing	low	A conservation cause and a global hook
The public storm (petition, media)	45-70%	months	low	A government forced to pause
Broad coalition	45-70%	ongoing	low	A wide, hard-to-dismiss movement
Court challenge, up to the Supreme Court	35-60%	1-4 years	low-moderate	A deal quashed; the beach secured
International attention	40-65%	ongoing	low	Pressure on the government and partner
All steps (harm clear, storm raised, coalition broad)	45-70%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Stopped; halted; secured in court
All steps (community divided, strong jobs pitch)	25-50%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Delay; the record; partial

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Sierra Leone's real strengths are distinctive — the **fisheries-and-food case**, the **pristine-ecosystem cause**, the **public storm**, the **broad coalition**, and the **courts**. Its constraints are specific: the community may be **divided**; the government may **defend the project** and depend on a **foreign partner**; the win may take **years**; and the **wider threat continues**.

A note on cost: making the fisheries case, raising the storm, building the coalition, and reaching the courts cost mainly

time, unity, and the help of allies, and Sierra Leone's fishing communities, conservationists, and civil society supply real energy. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the breadth of the coalition and the force of the public storm, joined to a case carried to the courts — exactly what the defenders of Black Johnson brought.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Sierra Leone are **the fisheries-and-food case, the public storm, and the broad coalition**, backed by the pristine-ecosystem cause and the courts. Black Johnson shows the ceiling: a broad coalition made the case for the fisheries, raised a storm, and carried it to the Supreme Court, and the beach was saved. But the honest floor is real too: the community was divided, the government defended the project, the win took years, and the wider threat continues. Most Sierra Leonean fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the fisheries case, the storm, the coalition, and the courts are powerful levers — decisive when the harm is clear and the coalition broad, weaker when the community is divided or the jobs pitch prevails, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and a partial gain. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a campaign that can show a clear threat to the fisheries and the food, raise a broad coalition and a loud storm, and carry a rigorous case to the courts is in the strong band and can aim to stop even a foreign-funded megaproject, as Black Johnson did; a campaign whose community is divided by the promise of jobs, or whose harm is harder to show, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a record, and a partial gain while it works to unite the community and sharpen the case. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The fisheries-and-food case and the public storm** — Sierra Leone's most distinctive levers; the threat to the fisheries and the nation's food, and the storm it raises, as at Black Johnson.
2. **The broad coalition** — the fishing communities, landowners, conservationists, and public, standing together, as they stood at Black Johnson.
3. **The courts, up to the Supreme Court** — the legal challenge that secured the decisive victory at Black Johnson.
4. **The pristine-ecosystem cause** — the forest, the lagoon, the turtles that gave the fight a conservation cause and a global hook.
5. **The international attention** — the global concern that pressured the government and the foreign partner.

What Sierra Leonean Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The fisheries and the food rouse the nation** — the threat to the fish and the food was the campaign's unifying force. **A public storm forces a pause** — the petition and the media forced the government's hand. **The courts can secure the win** — the Supreme Court sealed Black Johnson. **A broad coalition is hard to dismiss** — fishers, landowners, and conservationists together carried weight. **But the community may be divided and the win slow** — some backed the project for jobs, and the win took years. The through-line: **make the case for the fisheries and the food; raise the public storm; build the broad coalition; carry it to the courts; and draw international attention** — because in Sierra Leone a determined coalition can stop even a foreign-funded megaproject.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact deal that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds, which in Sierra Leone is often the fisheries case, the public storm, and the courts. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the harbour and fishmeal plant that would devastate our fisheries and our food, on a flawed process, which we can carry to the courts" is a campaign — the kind that saved Black Johnson. Answer five questions — and honestly weigh a sixth, about development.

The Core Questions

1. Does it harm the fisheries, the fish stocks, and the food? This is the first Sierra Leonean question. Does the project — a fishmeal plant, an industrial harbour, another development — **devastate the fisheries, the fish stocks, and the nation's food**, threatening the artisanal fishers and food security, as Black Johnson's plant would have. This should be the very first thing a campaign establishes, because the fisheries-and-food dimension is what gives a fight of this kind its national reach. A project that threatens only a local amenity may struggle to rouse the country; one that threatens the fish stocks the whole nation eats and the livelihoods of coastal communities across the land engages an interest far wider than the affected place. Establishing early, with evidence, exactly how the project would harm the fisheries — the stocks it would consume, the breeding grounds it would poison, the fishers and the food it would undercut — tells a community whether it holds this powerful national lever, as Black Johnson's defenders held it.

2. Does it destroy a pristine or protected ecosystem? Does it destroy a **protected forest, a fish-breeding lagoon, nesting grounds, or other pristine ecosystem** — the conservation cause and global hook, as Black Johnson's forest and lagoon were.

3. Can a public storm and a broad coalition be raised? Can a **petition, a media storm, and a broad coalition** of fishers, landowners, conservationists, and the public be raised, as they were at Black Johnson. Assess this honestly at the outset, because the ability to raise a genuine public storm and to hold a broad coalition together is what turns a documented harm into a force that moves a government. A storm requires more than a grievance; it requires a cause the public will take up — the nation's food, a beloved beach, a pristine forest — and channels through which to raise it, from social media to the national press to a petition that gathers real numbers. A campaign must reckon frankly with whether it can raise such a storm and, crucially, whether it can hold its coalition together against the effort to divide it with the promise of jobs. The Black Johnson campaign could do both; a community should assess honestly whether it can, and build the storm and the coalition deliberately from the start.

4. Was the process lawful, and can it be carried to the courts? Was the **process, the land acquisition, and the environmental review** lawful, or flawed — the ground the courts can act on, as the Black Johnson process was challenged to the Supreme Court. Give this question close attention, because the lawfulness of the process is often where the decisive legal case is found. A large land-and-infrastructure deal, especially one pushed through quickly to please a foreign partner, frequently cuts corners the law does not permit — an environmental review skipped or rushed, land acquired without proper process or consent, permits granted without the required steps — and each such flaw is a distinct ground on which a court can act. It was the pursuit of exactly such grounds, through the courts to the highest bench, that ultimately secured Black Johnson; a community that scrutinises not only the harm of a project but the lawfulness of how it was approved often finds there the legal purchase that, carried far enough, can strike the whole deal down.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which government body, foreign partner, and company are behind it, who profits; and which courts, organisations, press, and public can be engaged.

6. What development does it promise, and how do you weigh it honestly? What **development, jobs, or benefit** does the project promise, dividing the community — and how do you **weigh and answer it honestly**, because a Sierra Leonean fight of this kind must reckon openly with the development the project claims, as Black Johnson's did. This question is not optional here.

A Worked Example

Suppose an industrial harbour and fishmeal plant would devastate the fisheries and destroy a pristine forest and lagoon, promising development.

Working the questions: does it harm the **fisheries and the food**? Does it destroy a **pristine ecosystem**? Can a **storm and coalition** be raised? Was the **process lawful**? And what **development** does it promise, weighed how? The deciders are the government and the foreign partner, with the courts, the coalition, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the government has signed" to a target list: make the case for the fisheries and the food; raise the storm; build the coalition; challenge the process in court; and weigh the development honestly. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how a beach was saved. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a sense that the government had signed with a partner too strong to cross into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — make the fisheries case, raise the storm, build the coalition, challenge in court, weigh the development — each tied to a specific lever that Sierra Leone genuinely provides. That reframing, from resignation to a plan built on the nation's food and the reach of the courts, is the difference the questions make, and the first of them, whether the harm to the fisheries and the food can be shown, often decides how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, an official, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Sierra Leone, the harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem, the flawed process, and the honest weighing of the development are precisely what a campaign turns into pressure, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Deal, the Process, and the Fisheries Harm

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **project plans, the agreement, the land acquisition, and the environmental review** — and scrutinise them for flaws: was the review proper, the harm to the fisheries faced, the process lawful? And document the **harm to the fisheries** — how a fishmeal plant or industrial harbour would strip the fish stocks, poison the breeding grounds, and undercut the artisanal fishers and the food supply, as Black Johnson's defenders documented it. The gap between what the process required and what was done, and the harm to the fisheries, is where many Sierra Leonean cases are grounded. The harm to the fisheries deserves the most rigorous documentation of all, because it is both the campaign's broadest argument and, where the government denies the danger, the point most in dispute. It is not enough to assert that a plant would harm the fishing; the case must show, with evidence, how a fishmeal facility of the proposed scale would consume the small fish that the stocks and the fishers depend on, how its discharges would poison the breeding grounds, and how the loss would ripple through the food supply and the coastal economy. At Black Johnson the government insisted the facility was merely a harbour, not a fishmeal plant, which made the documentation of what was truly proposed — and of what such a plant would do — all the more important; a community should document the fisheries harm precisely enough to survive that kind of denial.

Layer 2: The Harm to the Ecosystem and the Food

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **sea, the forest, and the food** at the centre. Record the **harm** — to the fisheries, the fish stocks, the food security, the protected forest, the breeding lagoon, the nesting turtles — that the project would cause, as Black Johnson's defenders recorded the threat to the beach, the lagoon, and the forest. The conservation dimension deserves documentation with particular care, because it is what carries the fight beyond the nation's borders to an international audience whose attention can shift the outcome. A pristine rainforest sheltering endangered primates, a lagoon that breeds the fish of a coast, beaches where turtles nest — these are not merely local amenities but part of a global natural heritage, and their documented threat draws the concern of international conservation organisations, the world's press, and audiences that pressure both a government and a foreign partner sensitive to their image. A community that documents the ecological value and the threat with rigour — the species, the habitats, the breeding grounds — arms the international dimension of its campaign, which at Black Johnson helped turn a national fight into a cause the world was watching. Document what would be **lost**. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from the fishers and the community, and gather the **scientific evidence** on the fisheries, the ecosystem, and the impact. This is the case that rouses the nation and gives the fight a conservation cause.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Flaw, and the Honest Reckoning

Finally, document the case — and, distinctively in Sierra Leone, document the **honest reckoning** with the development too. Is the **harm** to the fisheries, the food, and the ecosystem real and grave? Was the **process flawed**? And what **development** does the project promise, and how do you **answer it honestly** (a truer accounting of the costs and benefits, a better path, the jobs that would be lost in the fisheries)? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, the storm, and the coalition — and together they make a case that is both strong and honest. This is the layer that most often decides Sierra Leonean fights of this kind, because here a project sold as development is revealed to devastate the fisheries and the food, to destroy a pristine ecosystem, to rest on a flawed process, and to promise a development that does not outweigh what it destroys — exactly the case that saved Black Johnson. The strength of assembling all these grounds together — the harm to the fisheries and the food, the destruction of a pristine ecosystem, the flaws in the process, and an honest reckoning with the development — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the fisheries harm rouses the nation, the ecosystem draws the world, the flawed process gives the courts something to act on, and the honest reckoning answers the one argument — development — that could otherwise divide the community. A campaign that assembles only some of these leaves an opening: it may rouse the nation but lose in court, or win a legal point but be split by the jobs pitch. The campaigns that prevail in Sierra Leone, as Black Johnson's did, build all of them and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Sierra Leonean cases of this kind, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem, the flawed process, and the honest reckoning.

The Deal, the Process, and the Paper Trail

- **The project plans and the agreement** — the deal, its terms, and the foreign partner behind it.
- **The land acquisition** — how the land was acquired, and whether lawfully and with consent.
- **The environmental review** — the assessment behind the project, and its adequacy.
- **The fisheries and food data** — the fish stocks, the artisanal fisheries, and the food they provide.
- **The proponent and the beneficiaries** — who profits, and how the project fits the government's plans.

How to Get Them

The plans, agreement, land acquisition, and review are matters of record, obtainable from the authorities and through public and civil-society sources; the fisheries and food data through the fisheries authorities, the fishing communities, and independent research; the foreign partner's role through public sources. Lean on **allies**: Sierra Leone's fishing communities, its conservation and civil-society organisations, its lawyers, and the international organisations that know the fisheries and the ecosystem, as they knew them at Black Johnson. Move promptly: documenting the harm and the flawed process early lets you raise the storm and reach the courts before the project hardens, as the Black Johnson campaign moved while the deal was fresh. Timing matters here in a particular way, because a foreign-funded megaproject gathers momentum and sunk investment the longer it proceeds, and becomes harder to stop once construction and land clearing are under way. A deal freshly announced, its review still open to challenge and its ground not yet broken, can be contested on far more favourable terms than one already built; and an early, loud public storm can force a pause before the partner and the government are deeply committed. The Black Johnson campaign moved quickly once the deal became known, raising its storm and beginning its challenge while the project was still on paper; a community should aim to document the harm, raise the storm, and mount the legal challenge as early as it can, before the momentum of the project hardens against it.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — to the fisheries, the food, the forest, the lagoon, the turtles, documented.
- **The flawed process** — the gaps in the review, the land acquisition, the consent.
- **The honest reckoning** — the development the project promises, and your honest answer.
- **The fisheries and food data** — the numbers that show the threat to the fish and the food.
- **Testimony and science** — from the fishers, the community, and the scientists.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the deal, the process, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom — the court, the press, the public. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a fisher, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, and a judge — up to the Supreme Court — all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the government or the partner pushes back — especially dangerous where the government contests the harm, as Sierra Leone's did over the fishmeal plant. In a country where the fisheries case and the courts decide, the community with the better-documented, more honest file — one that both proves the harm and fairly answers the development — is very often the one that saves its beach and its fishery, as the defenders of Black Johnson did.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE BROAD COALITION AND RAISE THE STORM

Evidence does not win on its own. A broad coalition that raises a storm does — and in Sierra Leone, Black Johnson proved that fishing communities, landowners, conservationists, and the public, standing together and raising a storm, can stop a foreign-funded megaproject. A campaign's strength here is that breadth and that storm: the coalition wide, the storm loud,

and the case carried to the courts.

Phase 1: The Core and the Fisheries

Start with a committed core rooted in the **fishing communities and the affected landowners** — because in Sierra Leone the threat to the fisheries and the food, and the stand of those whose land and livelihoods are at stake, is a decisive lever, as it was at Black Johnson. Assign roles — documentation, the legal case, the storm, media, and coalition liaison. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the beach and the fishery saved — and on what the community will and will not accept. And face the **division** honestly: work to bring in those tempted by the promised jobs, with an honest account of what the fisheries provide and what would be lost.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **fishing communities and the landowners**; the **conservation and civil-society organisations**, which bring the campaigning and the expertise, as they did at Black Johnson; the **scientists**, on the fisheries and the ecosystem; sympathetic **lawyers**, who can carry it to the courts; the **international organisations**, whose reach and attention are decisive; and the **wider public**, at home and in the diaspora, whom the threat to the nation's food and a pristine beach can move. Reach the **press and social media**, because a foreign-funded plant devouring a beloved beach and the nation's fish is a national and international story. The Black Johnson campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — fishers, landowners, conservationists, and a roused public — which is precisely the spread a winning Sierra Leonean campaign of this kind needs. The breadth of that coalition deserves particular emphasis, because it was both the source of the campaign's strength and its answer to the attempt to divide it. A movement that unites the fishing communities whose food and livelihood are at stake, the landowners whose land is threatened, the conservationists who value the ecosystem, and a wider public roused by the loss of a national treasure is far harder to dismiss or to split than any one of these alone — and harder to caricature, since it plainly is not merely the preference of one group. The Black Johnson campaign drew its force from spanning the fishers and the landowners, the local and the national, the conservationist and the ordinary citizen; a campaign should build that breadth deliberately, both for the weight it carries and because a broad coalition is the surest guard against being divided.

A worked coalition example. Facing a harbour and fishmeal plant, the fishing communities and landowners form the base; the conservation organisations bring the campaign and the cause; the scientists document the harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem; the lawyers carry it to the Supreme Court; the international allies bring the reach; and the press and social media raise the storm. No single group could carry it; together they cover the fisheries, the ecosystem, the law, and the public — the model Black Johnson built.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Sierra Leonean fight of this kind can run for years, as Black Johnson's ran to the Supreme Court. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the harm documented, the petition swelling, a media wave, a government pause, a court filing, a ruling. Keep the coalition broad and the storm alive, and guard against the **division, the discouragement, and the jobs pressure** — the promise that the project brings development, the offer to split the community, the slow grind of the courts — that will be used against you. Meet the jobs pressure honestly, and keep the coalition together, because a movement that answers the development squarely and holds its breadth outlasts a government and a foreign partner, as Black Johnson's did.

Phase 4: Raising the Storm and Reaching the Courts

Here is Sierra Leone's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, **raise the storm**: build the **petition, the media wave, and the national and international attention** that force a government to pause, as the storm forced the pause at Black Johnson. Second, **reach the courts**: carry the fight, on the harm and the flawed process, to the **courts, up to the Supreme Court**, whose ruling can secure the win, as it secured Black Johnson. Keep it **broad, loud, honest about the development, and carried to the courts**, because in Sierra Leone it is the broad coalition that raises a storm and reaches the courts, more than any single confrontation, that stops a megaproject — as it stopped the plant at Black Johnson.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE ENVIRONMENT, THE PROCESS, AND THE COURTS

Sierra Leone's environmental and fisheries law, its process, and its courts — up to the Supreme Court — are a real and, at Black Johnson, decisive toolkit. You do not need to win at once: a government pause, a flawed process exposed, a delay while you raise the storm, a case carried to the courts, or a project abandoned under pressure can each be a real victory, and the lasting one is a court ruling that secures the place. Engage lawyers early — but understand the tools.

The Environmental and Fisheries Law

The first lever is the **environmental and fisheries law**. Sierra Leone has **environmental protection and fisheries law** — the Fisheries and Aquaculture law, the environmental-assessment requirements — and a project that **breaches them**, devastating the fisheries, destroying a protected ecosystem, or proceeding without a proper environmental review, runs against that law, as the Black Johnson project was said to. Establish the breaches precisely; they are both a legal ground and the material of the storm. It is worth being clear-eyed about how the law and the storm work together here, because neither alone was enough at Black Johnson. The documented breaches of the environmental and fisheries law — the inadequate review, the harm to protected fish stocks, the failures of process — gave the campaign the grounds on which the courts could eventually act; but it was the public storm that kept the case alive, forced the initial government pause, and sustained the pressure through the years the litigation took. A campaign that documents the illegalities without raising the storm may find its case slow and ignored; one that raises the storm without the legal grounds may win a pause that later evaporates. The lasting victory at Black Johnson came from joining the two — the rigorous legal case and the loud, sustained public pressure — all the way to the Supreme Court.

The Process and the Land Acquisition

The second lever is the **process and the land acquisition**. A project requires a **lawful process, a proper environmental review, and a lawful acquisition of land**, and a deal made on a **flawed review, without proper consent, or by an unlawful taking of land** is open to challenge, as questions were raised about the Black Johnson process and land. Document how the process and the acquisition were flawed; this is both a legal weakness and a public argument.

The Courts, Up to the Supreme Court

The third lever, and the one that sealed Black Johnson, is the **courts, up to the Supreme Court**. Sierra Leone's **courts can rule on the lawfulness of a project**, and a case carried, with persistence, to the **Supreme Court** can secure a decisive and lasting victory, as the Supreme Court ruled in favour of the Black Johnson campaign. Carry the fight to the courts, and, where the stakes justify it, to the highest court, because a ruling there secures the place beyond the reach of a single government's will.

Where to Turn and With Whom

The environmental and fisheries grounds go through the **authorities and the courts**; the process and land challenges through the **courts**; the decisive challenge through the **courts, up to the Supreme Court**. Get help early: Sierra Leone's lawyers and conservation and civil-society organisations, and the international allies, know the environmental and fisheries law, the process, and the courts, as they knew them at Black Johnson. Help engaged early is worth far more than help sought after, and in Sierra Leone the strongest strategy marries the **legal challenge, up to the Supreme Court** to the **public storm and the broad coalition**, so that a project devastating the fisheries and resting on a flawed process is both stormed in public and struck down in court — as Black Johnson was.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an official, a journalist, and the public in different ways. And in Sierra Leone, distinctively, you must also learn to answer the development a project promises, honestly and well.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a fishmeal plant and harbour would strip the fish stocks the nation eats and the artisanal fishers depend on, destroy a protected forest and a fish-breeding lagoon, on a flawed process, while being pitched as development. That one fact becomes:

- **A fisheries-and-food argument:** the project would devastate the fish the nation eats and the fishers depend on —

the case that rouses the nation.

- **A legal argument:** the process and the environmental review were flawed and unlawful — the case before the courts, up to the Supreme Court.
- **A conservation argument:** a protected forest, a breeding lagoon, and nesting turtles would be destroyed — the case that draws national and international concern.
- **An honest-development argument:** development matters, but this project destroys more than it brings, and here honestly is why — the case that answers the jobs pitch without dodging it.
- **A public argument:** they would sell our beach and our fish to a foreign plant — the case that raises the storm.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience — and, distinctively, how it answers the development. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Sierra Leone the arguments that most often decide things are the **fisheries-and-food** one, because it rouses the nation, and the **honest-development** one, because a project sold as development must be answered honestly to be beaten. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the data and a claim made to a judge can be proven by the review; honesty across audiences, especially about the development, is the source of a campaign's credibility.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts, up to the Supreme Court, want the flawed process and the breach of the environmental and fisheries law framed against the statutes, with the documents that prove them.

The government responds to the public storm, the fisheries harm, the legal risk, and an honest reckoning with the development.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a foreign-funded plant devouring a beloved beach and the nation's fish, on a flawed process.

The public needs the argument clear and true: our beach, our forest, our fish — sold for a project that destroys more than it brings.

The conservation and international world responds to the threat to the protected ecosystem and the fisheries.

Those tempted by the jobs need an honest account of the development — the fisheries jobs that would be lost, the truer costs and benefits — offered with respect, not scorn.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Sierra Leone, where a foreign-funded plant devouring a beloved beach and the nation's fish stirs a nation, the public storm is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage rouses the nation, pressures the government, and draws international attention. The Black Johnson campaign forced a government pause in large part by raising a storm — a petition of tens of thousands and a wave of national and international attention that a government could not ignore.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the fisheries, the beach, and the honesty. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a foreign-funded plant would strip the nation's fish and destroy a pristine beach and forest, on a flawed process" is — the kind of story that stormed Black Johnson. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the harm to the fisheries and the food, the pristine ecosystem, the flawed process — and answer the development honestly, and offer a human voice: a fisher, a conservationist, a resident. In Sierra Leone the story of a beloved beach and the nation's fish sold to a foreign plant is one the nation and the world respond to.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets and social media** — because national opinion and the online storm pressure the government, as they did at Black Johnson. Then the **international ring** — the international press, the conservation and fisheries networks, and the audiences that care about oceans and land rights — because a foreign-funded plant devouring a protected beach and a nation's fish is a global story, and

international attention pressures both the government and the foreign partner. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national storm and the international ring are both decisive** in Sierra Leone.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Sierra Leonean fight of this kind runs for years. Plan a sequence — the deal, the harm, the petition, the pause, the court ruling — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and — distinctively — honest about the development; the government and the partner will seize on any exaggeration or any dodge of the jobs argument, and a credible, fisheries-and-ecosystem-centred, honestly-argued campaign is what raises a storm a government cannot ignore. Verified, specific, fisheries-and-beach-centred, honest, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped save Black Johnson.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the authorities, the courts, the foreign partner, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the fisheries harm, the process, and the honest reckoning.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant authority **Subject:** Request for information on [project]

We, [community/organisation], request the **project plans, the agreement, the land acquisition, and the environmental review** for [project]. This project affects our fisheries, our food, our land, and the public interest, and the public has a right to know. Please provide the documents.

8B. Objection During the Process

To: the relevant ministry / authority **Subject:** Objection to [project] — harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem

We, [community/organisation], object to [project]. It would **devastate our fisheries and the nation's food**, destroy **[the protected forest / lagoon / beach]**, and rests on a **flawed process and environmental review**. We ask that it be **refused or reviewed**, and we reserve our right to the courts.

8C. The Petition

To: the government / the President **Subject:** Petition to stop [project] and save [the beach / the fishery]

We, the undersigned — [number] citizens of Sierra Leone and beyond — call on the government to **stop [project]**, which would devastate our fisheries and our food, destroy a pristine ecosystem, and take a beloved beach. We ask that the deal be **cancelled** and [the beach / the area] **protected**. [Signatures.]

8D. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the court (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to [project]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge [project] as **unlawful**: it breaches the **environmental and fisheries law**, rests on a **flawed review and an unlawful land acquisition**, and would devastate the fisheries and destroy a protected ecosystem. We seek that it be **halted and quashed**, and, where the stakes justify it, we will carry this challenge to the **Supreme Court**.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Organisation

To: a public-interest lawyer / conservation or civil-society organisation **Subject:** [Project] — the fisheries harm, the process, and the challenge

We are opposing [project]. We attach the agreement, the review, and our evidence of harm to the fisheries and the

ecosystem, and seek advice on **the environmental and fisheries-law grounds, the process and land challenge,** and **carrying it to the Supreme Court.** Please advise on the strongest routes.

8F. Answering the Development Argument (Public Letter)

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** On [project] and the development it promises

We, [community/organisation], take the **development and jobs** promised by [project] seriously, and we answer honestly. [The fisheries jobs and food that would be lost, the truer costs and benefits, a better path.] We can seek development and still defend our fisheries and our beach — and this project destroys more than it brings. We ask that the honest reckoning, not the promise, decide.

8G. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the beach / the fishery / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a story of national and international interest, with a clear hook: [documents] show [finding — e.g. "a foreign-funded plant would strip the nation's fish and destroy a pristine beach, on a flawed process"]. It echoes Black Johnson. I can share the file and connect you with a fisher and a conservationist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/organisation] opposes [project]

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would **devastate our fisheries and our food** and destroy **[the beach / the ecosystem]** for a foreign-funded plant, on a flawed process. As the defenders of Black Johnson raised a storm and won at the Supreme Court, we will make the case for our fisheries, raise the storm, build the coalition, and carry the fight to the courts. We will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an objection, a petition, or a challenge is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the government, and the world will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the fisheries harm, the process, and the honest reckoning; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the community, the organisations, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in Sierra Leone that record feeds the levers that matter most: the fisheries case, the public storm, the broad coalition, and the courts that saved Black Johnson.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a years-long campaign to the Supreme Court. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to defend your fishery and your beach. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Document the fisheries harm.** Establish how the project would devastate the fish, the food, and the ecosystem (Step 2, 8A).
- 2. Object on the record.** Put your objection, the fisheries harm, and the flawed process on the record (8B).
- 3. Raise the petition.** Start a petition and gather signatures, at home and abroad (8C).
- 4. Reach the organisations and lawyers.** Connect with conservation and civil-society organisations and lawyers (8E).
- 5. Answer the development.** Set out honestly why the project destroys more than it brings (8F).
- 6. Raise the storm.** Take the fisheries and the beach to the press and social media (Step 5, 8G).
- 7. Carry it to the courts.** With a lawyer, challenge the project — up to the Supreme Court if the stakes justify it (8D).

Do only the first three and you will have documented the harm, objected, and raised a petition — the foundation of a Sierra Leonean defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: document the fisheries

harm, object, raise the petition.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Sierra Leone's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. **Powerful foreign partners and financiers**, and a government that champions their megaprojects as development, carry great weight, and a project is presented as jobs and investment for a poor country. The **government can depend on a foreign partner** — a major aid-giver and investor — and be **reluctant to act** against it, as Sierra Leone has been hesitant to act against a powerful partner even over its fleets. The **promise of development can divide** a community that badly needs work. And **land and environmental governance can be weak**, deals done with little review. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that dismisses the development argument, or assumes the government will act against a powerful partner, will be disappointed — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to make the fisheries case, raise a storm too loud to ignore, answer the development honestly, and carry it to the courts, which a foreign partner cannot capture.

What Still Works — And Much Is Strong

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real levers remain — and some are strong.

The fisheries-and-food case still rouses. The threat to the fish the nation eats and the fishers depend on is a powerful, unifying argument.

The public storm still forces a pause. A petition and a wave of attention can push a government to halt, as at Black Johnson.

The courts still rule. Sierra Leone's courts, up to the Supreme Court, can strike down a project, beyond a foreign partner's reach.

The pristine ecosystem still draws the world. A protected forest, a breeding lagoon, and nesting turtles draw international concern.

The broad coalition still prevails. Fishers, landowners, and conservationists together are hard to dismiss.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Sierra Leone is realistic but genuinely hopeful: the government tilts toward powerful foreign partners and their development, and the community may be divided, but the fisheries case, the public storm, the broad coalition, and the courts give a campaign real, and sometimes strong, levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: make the case for the **fisheries and the food**; raise the **public storm**; build the **broad coalition**; **answer the development** honestly; and carry it to the **courts** — while understanding that the community may be divided, the government may resist, and the win may take years. Do not assume the government will act against a powerful partner unprompted; Black Johnson was saved because a broad coalition raised a storm and carried the fight to the Supreme Court.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sierra Leone has real and documented concerns about corruption and the capture of decisions by powerful interests, foreign and domestic, so this section matters. When a deal is driven not by the public interest but by the connected, or by a foreign partner's weight over the institutions, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **deal signed against the public interest and the fisheries**; land **acquired or sold without proper process or consent**; an **environmental review skipped or shaded**; **close ties** between the

foreign partner, the officials, and the connected; a government **reluctant to act** against a powerful partner; and **benefits to the connected and the partner** while the fishers and the nation lose their food. Trace the deal and the interests: who signed it, who profits, whether the process was bypassed for the connected or the partner. In Sierra Leone, a deal that hands a beach and a fishery to a foreign plant against the law is worth examining for the influence behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where influence reaches. **Parts of the government and the institutions** can be captured or pressured by powerful foreign and domestic interests. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, and above all the **Supreme Court**, beyond the reach of a foreign partner; the **international press and organisations**; the **fishing communities**, whose livelihoods are at stake; the **free press and social media**; and the **public**, at home and in the diaspora. Distinctively, the courts and the public storm are hard for a foreign partner to capture; your task is to document the capture, raise the storm, and carry it to the courts.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured deal cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the deal was signed, the land taken, the review skipped, who profits — and take it to the forces that can act: the **courts, up to the Supreme Court**; the **international press and organisations**; the **free press and social media**; and the **public and the fishers**. Pair the exposure with the fisheries case and the flawed process, so the impropriety and the harm arrive together. In Sierra Leone, exposing how a beach and a fishery were handed to a foreign plant against the law, and carrying it to the Supreme Court where a foreign partner's influence cannot reach, is often the way to undo it — as the storm and the court secured Black Johnson.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Sierra Leone turns on the fisheries case, the public storm, and the courts.

Early (Months 0-8): The Harm, the Storm, and the Coalition

Pin down the deal and the deciding bodies (Step 1); document the **harm to the fisheries and the ecosystem** and the **flawed process** (Step 2). Build the **broad coalition** and begin to **raise the storm** (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); **object on the record** (8B); **raise the petition** (8C); reach **lawyers and organisations** early (8E); and begin to **answer the development** (8F). This phase lays the foundation, and in Sierra Leone the documented harm, the storm, and the coalition established here are what win.

Middle (Months 6-36): Storm, Challenge, and Endure

Sustain the coalition and the storm (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience, honestly answering the development (Turning Evidence). Mount the **legal challenge**, and carry it, with persistence, toward the **Supreme Court** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, at home and internationally (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — raising the storm and challenging before the project hardens — because those chances are most powerful early.

Later (Months 12-many): The Ruling, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **project stopped, the beach and fishery saved, secured by a court ruling** — and then stay vigilant, because, as Black Johnson showed, the win may take years and the wider plunder of the fisheries by foreign fleets continues. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped and secured by the Supreme Court. Sometimes it is a government pause won by the storm, to be sealed later in court, or a partial gain to be defended. Both, where they save the fishery and the beach, are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-8	Document the fisheries harm + flawed process Build the coalition Object + petition Answer the development
MONTHS 6-36	Legal challenge toward the Supreme Court Sustain the storm International attention Media
MONTHS 12-many	Project stopped / secured by court ruling Stay vigilant, for the wider plunder continues

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Sierra Leone gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **fisheries-and-food case** — the threat to the fish the nation eats and the artisanal fishers depend on — is a powerful, unifying argument. The **pristine-ecosystem cause** — a protected forest, a breeding lagoon, nesting turtles — gives the fight a conservation cause and a global hook. The **public storm** — a petition, a media wave — can force a government to pause. The **broad coalition** — fishers, landowners, conservationists, and the public — is hard to dismiss. And the **courts, up to the Supreme Court**, can secure a decisive and lasting win. These are the tools that let the defenders of Black Johnson stop a foreign-funded megaproject and save a beach and a fishery.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The community was **divided** — some backed the project for the development and jobs it promised, and the fight carried a real tension between development and the environment. The government **defended the project** and depended on a powerful **foreign partner** it was reluctant to cross. The win came only **after years** and a Supreme Court ruling. And Black Johnson was **one beach**, while the wider plunder of the fisheries continues. No guide should pretend these away; in Sierra Leone, the art is to make the fisheries case, raise the storm, answer the development honestly, carry it to the courts, and keep watch, because one beach saved is one win in a wider fight.

So the realistic promise is this: **make the case for the fisheries and the food; raise the public storm; build the broad coalition; answer the development honestly; and carry it to the courts — running all of it together.** Do that, and where the harm is clear and the coalition broad, you can stop even a foreign-funded megaproject and secure the win in court, as Black Johnson did; where the community is divided or the jobs pitch prevails, you can still win delay, a record, and a partial gain. Do it as the defenders of Black Johnson did — fishers, landowners, and conservationists who made the case for their fishery, raised a storm, and carried the fight to the Supreme Court.

A last word on the fisheries and the courts. Sierra Leone's lesson is that a broad coalition, making the case for the fish that feed a nation and the beach that shelters them, can raise a storm too loud for a government to ignore and carry the fight to a court a foreign partner cannot capture — but that the community may be divided by the promise of development, the government may resist, the win may take years, and the wider plunder goes on. The powerful count on your believing the deal is signed with a partner too strong to cross, or on dividing you with the promise of jobs. Their advantage is the foreign money, the development pitch, and the government's dependence. Yours is the fisheries the nation eats, the pristine beach and forest, the public storm, the broad coalition, the courts up to the Supreme Court, and the proven fact that the defenders of Black Johnson saved their beach. Play to that. Keep the documented record and the proof of the fisheries harm, keep the coalition broad and the storm loud, answer the development honestly, carry it to the courts, and treat every signature, every objection, every wave of attention, and every ruling as a stone in a wall that even a foreign-funded megaproject cannot climb.

The tools are here, and Sierra Leone itself proved them: fishing communities, landowners, and conservationists who refused to let a beloved beach and the nation's fish be handed to a foreign-funded plant, made the case for their fisheries, raised a storm of tens of thousands, and carried the fight to the Supreme Court — which ruled to save Black Johnson. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the strength of the fisheries case, the force of the public storm, the breadth of the coalition, the honesty with which the development is answered, and the reach of the courts — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the fisheries harm and the storm and the coalition, and build from there. Communities before you have stopped a megaproject and saved their fishery — a project halted, a beach secured, a fishery defended. What the defenders of Black Johnson won can be won again. So can yours.